With No Immediate Cause and Woman, Do You Know

By Ntozake Shange and Lisa Dietz

INTRODUCTION

Domestic violence should not happen to anybody. Ever. Period. But it does - and when it does, there is help. Maybe you have lived with abuse, maybe it happened just once; maybe you work or live next to someone who is being abused right now. For all the women who have ever endured domestic abuse . . . the poetry of Ntozake Shange and Lisa Dietz speaks softly but strongly. With No Immediate Cause by Ntozake Shange

With No Immediate Cause

every 3 minutes a woman is beaten

every five minutes a

woman is raped/every ten minutes

a lil girl is molested

yet i rode the subway today

i sat next to an old man who

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may have beaten his old wife

3 minutes ago or 3 days/30 years ago

he might have sodomized his

daughter but i sat there

cuz the young men on the train

might beat some young women

later in the day or tomorrow

i might not shut my door fast

every 3 minutes it happens

some woman's innocence

rushes to her cheeks/pours from her mouth

like the betsy wetsy dolls have been torn

apart/their mouths

menses red & split/every

three minutes a shoulder

is jammed through plaster and the oven door/

chairs push thru the rib cage/hot water or

boiling sperm decorate her body

i rode the subway today

& bought a paper from a

man who might

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have held his old lady onto
a hot pressing iron/i don't know
maybe he catches lil girls in the
park & rips open their behinds
with steel rods/i can't decide
what he might have done i only
know every 3 minutes
every 5 minutes every 10 minutes/so
i bought the paper
looking for the announcement
the discovery/of the dismembered
woman's body/the
victims have not all been
identified/today they are
naked and dead/refuse to
testify/one girl out of 10's not
coherent/i took the coffee
& spit it up/i found an
announcement/not the woman's
bloated body in the river/floating
not the child bleeding in the

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59th street corridor/not the baby
broken on the floor/
there is some concern
that alleged battered women
might start to murder their
husbands & lovers with no
immediate cause"

i spit up i vomit i am screaming
we all have immediate cause
every 3 minutes
every 5 minutes
every 10 minutes
every day
women's bodies are found
in alleys & bedrooms/at the top of the stairs
before i ride the subway/buy a paper/drink
coffee/i must know/
have you hurt a woman today
did you beat a woman today
throw a child across a room

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are the lil girl's panties

in yr pocket

did you hurt a woman today

i have to ask these obscene questions

the authorities require me to

establish

immediate cause

every three minutes

every five minutes

every ten minutes

every day.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ntozake Shange
Book: Nappy Edges
ISBN: 978-0312064242
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TRANSITION

Women may be afraid of strangers, but it's a husband, a lover, a boyfriend, or someone they know who is most likely to hurt them. According to a U.S. Justice Department study, two-thirds of violent attacks against women are committed by someone the woman knows. In the United States, one of the most dangerous places for a woman is her own home. According to the FBI, approximately 1,500 women are killed each year by husbands or boyfriends. Lisa Dietz provides graphic insight into this brutal existence. Woman, Do You Know? By Lisa Dietz

Woman, Do You Know?

Woman

Do you know your name?

The one you had

Before the scars

Thick make-up covering

Sun-glassed face

Over red, blue, oily stains

Cropped hair in a fit of passion

Unpaid hospital bills

The broken nose, bruised ribs

Finger, elbow, knee, vagina

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Nothing left untouched.

Woman

Do you know where you live?

In a suburban house

Redwood fence

Haunting memory-dream reality

Locking doors, banging walls

Wipe away the blood

Scramble for the phone

The line is dead

As the door breaks down.

Woman

Do you remember who you were?

Little girl

Whistling carefully into blades of grass

Stomping out beetles

Climbing crop-branched trees

Your fairy palace fortress

Escape the noise

A dream of being married

Raising children

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A strong man

"He'll protect me

It'll be different then."

Woman

Do you see your children now?

Crouched like fetuses

Climbing beneath the covers

Stomping pillows on their ears

A wish for dreams

Praying, the way you taught them

"Please make daddy stop

Please let mommy

End the screaming."

Woman

Do you know what you really deserve?

When the time comes for apologies

Grasping the tenderness you live for

His lips wet on yours

Fingers tracing pain-lines on your face

"I'll never do it again, I promise."

DON'T BELIEVE IT.

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In the dawn of reprieval

Gather what's left

Before you're dead

Choke back fear

And find your escape.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lisa Dietz
Book: "Murphy Square: Unbound"
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